

Lycopus virginicus (Lamiaceae) Bugleweed

Description Perennial herb growing to 2 ft (60cm). Has a square stem, lance-shaped leaves, and whorls of whitish flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Bugleweed is common throughout most of North America, thriving close to water. It is harvested in summer when in flower.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Bugleweed contains phenolic acids (including derivatives of caffeic, chlorogenic, and ellagic acids).

History & Folklore In the 19th-century Physiomedicalist tradition, bugleweed was regarded as astringent and calming to the nerves, and was given for loose coughs, internal bleeding, and urinary incontinence. Herbal practitioners once considered the plant to be a mild narcotic.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Bugleweed has sedative properties and today the herb is principally prescribed to treat an overactive thyroid gland and the racing heartbeat that often accompanies this condition. Bugleweed is also considered an aromatic and tonic astringent that reduces the production of mucus.

Research Studies indicate that bugleweed and, to some degree, gipsywort (see *Related Species*, below) reduce the activity of the thyroid gland.

Related Species Gipsywort (*L. europaeus*), a European native, has astringent and cardiotonic properties. It is taken for palpitations and anxiety, and has been used to lower fever.

ⓘ **Cautions** Take only under professional supervision. Do not take during pregnancy.

Lysimachia vulgaris (Primulaceae) Yellow Loosestrife

Description Attractive perennial growing to 3 ft (1 m) with whorls of broadly lance-shaped leaves and bright yellow flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Europe, yellow loosestrife commonly grows in damp hedgerows and near water. It is also cultivated as a garden plant. It is gathered when in flower in summer.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Yellow loosestrife contains a benzoquinone, triterpenoid saponins, flavonoids, and tannins.

History & Folklore Pliny (23–79 CE) recorded that *lysimachia*, the plant's Latin name, was a tribute to King Lysimachus of Sicily, who discovered its medicinal benefits. The name "loosestrife" refers to the plant's reputed power to prevent conflict, particularly between animals, and to repel insects. The Greek physician

Dioscorides (40–90 CE) recommended loosestrife to staunch wounds and for nosebleeds, and noted that its smoke would drive away snakes and flies.

Medicinal Actions & Uses An astringent herb, yellow loosestrife is principally used to treat gastrointestinal conditions such as diarrhea and dysentery, to stop internal and external bleeding, and to cleanse wounds. It makes a workable mouthwash for sore gums and mouth ulcers, and may be used to treat nosebleeds. Yellow loosestrife has also been taken as an expectorant.

Related Species The yellow pimpernel (*L. nemorum*), another European native, is astringent and staunches blood. *Jin qian cao* (*L. christinae*), from China, is a diuretic used to treat urinary pain. A Chinese trial showed that the latter is also effective in treating both kidney stones and gallstones.

Lythrum salicaria (Lythraceae) Purple Loosestrife

Description Attractive perennial growing to about 5 ft (1.5 m). Has straight red stems, pointed lance-shaped leaves, and spikes of brilliant purple flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Purple loosestrife is native to Europe but well-established in the wild in North America. It thrives in marshes

and along rivers and streams, to altitudes of 3,300 ft (1,000 m). It is gathered when in flower in summer.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Purple loosestrife contains salicarin, a glycoside (vitexin), tannins, a volatile oil, mucilage, and plant sterols.

History & Folklore In 1654, the herbalist Nicholas Culpeper praised this herb, writing that "the distilled water is a present remedy for hurts and blows on the eyes, and for blindness ... it also cleareth the eyes of dust or any other thing gotten into them, and preserveth the sight." A common plant in Ireland, purple loosestrife was much used there against diarrhea.

Medicinal Actions & Uses The astringent purple loosestrife is mainly employed as a treatment for diarrhea and dysentery. It can be safely taken by people of all ages; some herbalists recommend it to help arrest diarrhea in breast-feeding babies. The herb may also be used to treat heavy periods and for inter-menstrual bleeding. Externally, it is applied as a poultice or lotion to wounds, leg ulcers, and eczema, and used to treat excess vaginal discharge and vaginal itching. Purple loosestrife is now little used to treat eye problems, but, as Culpeper's experience suggests, the herb could be worth further investigation as a remedy for disorders of the eyes and vision.

Research In animal experiments, extracts of the flowers and leaves have been shown to be hypoglycemic—lowering blood-sugar levels. The plant is also thought to have antibiotic activity.

Madhuca spp. (Sapotaceae) Butter Tree

Description Deciduous tree growing to 65 ft (20 m). Has leathery leaves, clusters of scented white flowers, and greenish fruit.

Habitat & Cultivation *Madhuca* species are native to central and northern India. The flowers, leaves, and seeds are gathered in summer.

Parts Used Flowers, seed oil.

Constituents The leaves contain an alkaloid and a saponin; the seeds a saponin and fixed oil.

History & Folklore Butter tree has been a source of food and medicine in India for at least 2,000 years. Its flowers are eaten and are fermented to make alcoholic drinks.

Medicinal Actions & Uses The expectorant flowers are used to treat chest problems such as bronchitis. They are also taken to increase breast-milk production. The leaves are applied as a poultice to eczema. The seed oil is laxative and is taken for constipation and to loosen the stool of hemorrhoid sufferers.

Purple loosestrife is used to relieve diarrhea and dysentery in breast-feeding babies.

